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From Co-creation to Concepts

HPB YPS Youth Project

Co-creation Findings & Report

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HMW

Addresses the fundamental desire to act, which is critical when competing interests like peer pressure, screen time, and convenience pull in different directions.

Recognises that healthy habits are co-produced rather than individual efforts. Key supporters includes parents, peers, teachers, and digital environments, acknowledging both the significant time youth spend in digital spaces and the opportunity to leverage these environments constructively.

“How might we motivate youth (aged 13–16) and their key supporters to build their confidence to start and sustain healthy habits across the 6 Wells (Eat, Sleep, Exercise, Learn, Bond, and Screen Time), so that healthier choices become natural, even as routines change and independence grows?”

Targets the internal belief system that transforms motivation into sustained action.

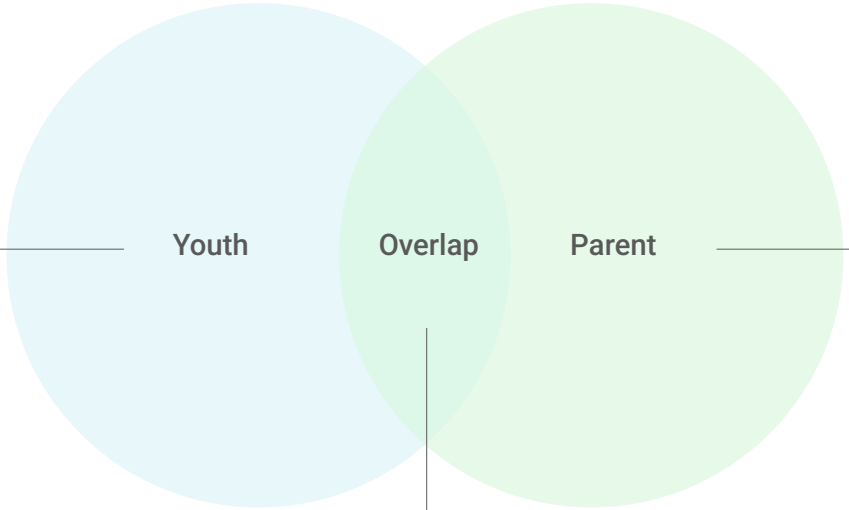
Tired youth choose whatever is quickest and requires the least effort, so we must make healthy options the automatic choice for an exhausted youth.

This targets the tricky gap where structure drops away but young people haven't yet learned how to manage their own time effectively.

The overlap: Where both sides meet and solutions belong

Youth

Youth are open to healthy routines even with rules (when they understand the reason behind them). What they resist are rules that feel one-sided or unexplained. They want practical guidance on how, not just the ‘why’.



Parent

Parents want to guide, not control. But as children grow, their parenting needs to evolve too. For many, the first child becomes the learning ground for figuring out what works. The instinct is right but the approach just hasn’t caught up yet.

Both parents and youth recognise the same problems: screens are eroding sleep, restriction triggers resistance not change, and trust is what holds everything together. Co-creation confirmed they share these concerns — they just experience them from different sides. The gap isn't awareness. It's that neither has practical strategies that work for both of them at the same time. That's where solutions belong.

This suggests that the focus should not be just on youth OR parents. **It's the rhythm they share.** Design needs to **give youth structure that doesn't feel imposed**, and **help parents evolve their approach** as their children's independence grows.

Most unhealthy choices happen where parent visibility is thinnest

In primary school, adults structured the whole day. In secondary, two large windows open up where unhealthy choices happen without any adult awareness or support.

Morning (6:30–7:30am)
Youth wakes to phone alarm, scrolls before getting up. Minimal breakfast if any.

Night (9pm–1am+)
"Window 2"
Phone in bedroom. No enforcement on bedtime. Sleep is entirely self-managed. The only "well" with no driver after parents withdraw.

School (8am–1:30pm)
The only fully structured window. PE, canteen, timetable — all held by school.
This is where HPB's current touchpoints sit.

Evening (6–9pm)
Parent presence returns but limited. Dinner if family eats together. Homework. Tuition 2–3x/week.

After School (2–6pm)
"Window 1"
~4 hours unsupervised. No Student Care Centre equivalent in secondary.
0 out of 6 parents present. Screen, snacks, peer influence fill the gap.

So what? What this means

We must design for the gap.

Parents cannot realistically fill after-school time, so the solution must work even when parents cannot see it.

Peers will shape choices in that gap.

If we want habits to stick, we need to make the healthier option easier in friend settings.

Replacement will work better than restriction

If we remove something without a better substitute, youth will find a workaround.

Move youth to healthy behaviour

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The X-Axis — From Knowing to Doing

The x-axis maps how far health knowledge translates into action.

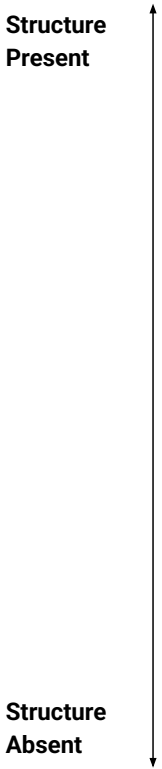
On the left: Know, Not Do. Youth can tell you what's healthy. They've heard the advice. But knowing doesn't change what they actually do — the easier choice still wins.

On the right: Know, And Do. Youth act on what they know not because someone is watching, but because they've built strategies that work for them.

Most youth aren't on the left because they don't care. They're there because no one has helped them **turn awareness into a practical routine that fits their real day.**

The Y-Axis — From Structure Present to Structure Absent

The y-axis maps whether someone is holding the routine in place.



At the top: **Structure Present.** Rules, routines, and adult supervision are active. In primary school, this is the default — parents, helpers, and Student Care Centres hold habits together.

At the bottom: **Structure Absent.** No one is enforcing, reminding, or watching. Youth are on their own. After-school hours, bedtime, and weekends live here.

The risk isn't that structure disappears, it has to. **The risk is that it disappears before youth have built the capability to replace it with their own.**

We want to move them from ‘Vicious’ to ‘Virtuous’ cycle

X-AXIS

The X-axis maps how far health knowledge translates into action. From knowing but not doing on one end to knowing and doing on the other.

Y-AXIS

The Y-axis shows the presence of structure. From structure absent at the bottom to structure present at the top.

WHAT THIS HELPS US SEE

The current state is a vicious cycle: youth drifts, parent adds structure, youth resists, both get stuck. The desired state is a virtuous line: practical strategy, small win, growing confidence, less need for control.

FROM VICIOUS TO VIRTUOUS

🔴 Vicious: Drift → Rules added → Youth pushes back → More rules or give up → Further drift. A loop.

🟢 Virtuous: Practical strategy → Small win → Feels capable → Parent adjusts approach → Builds on it. A line.

🔴 **Vicious Cycle** → 🟢 **Virtuous Cycle**

Structure Present

🔴 **Structured but resistant** → 🟢 **Supported and functioning**

Youth know what is right but follow rules to avoid trouble, not because they agree. They behave well when forced but get back to old habit after that

Help youth buy into the routine, not just follow it.

Routines are in place, and youth follow them naturally. During primary, habits seem formed, but they’re really held up by the people around them, not by themselves

Help youth take over before the support disappears.

Structure Absent

🔴 **The Drift** → 🟢 **Self-Managing**

Most youth spend after-school time with friends and little guidance. They know what’s healthy, but the easier choice still wins. Parents have less visibility here

Help youth build strategies for when the easier choice beats the healthier one.

Youth does healthy things without someone making them. Own routines, own strategies, own reasons. The north star.

Keep it going. Reinforce and celebrate.

Know, Not Do

Know, And Do

Primary 6 → Secondary 1: The big handover

WHAT CHANGES

Student Care Centre ends (no more 2-7pm coverage). Helper's role reduces. Youth gets a phone and a house key. First time choosing what to eat with pocket money. After-school time shifts from adult-supervised to peer-led. Parents go from seeing most of the day to seeing very little of it.

THE VICIOUS CYCLE HERE

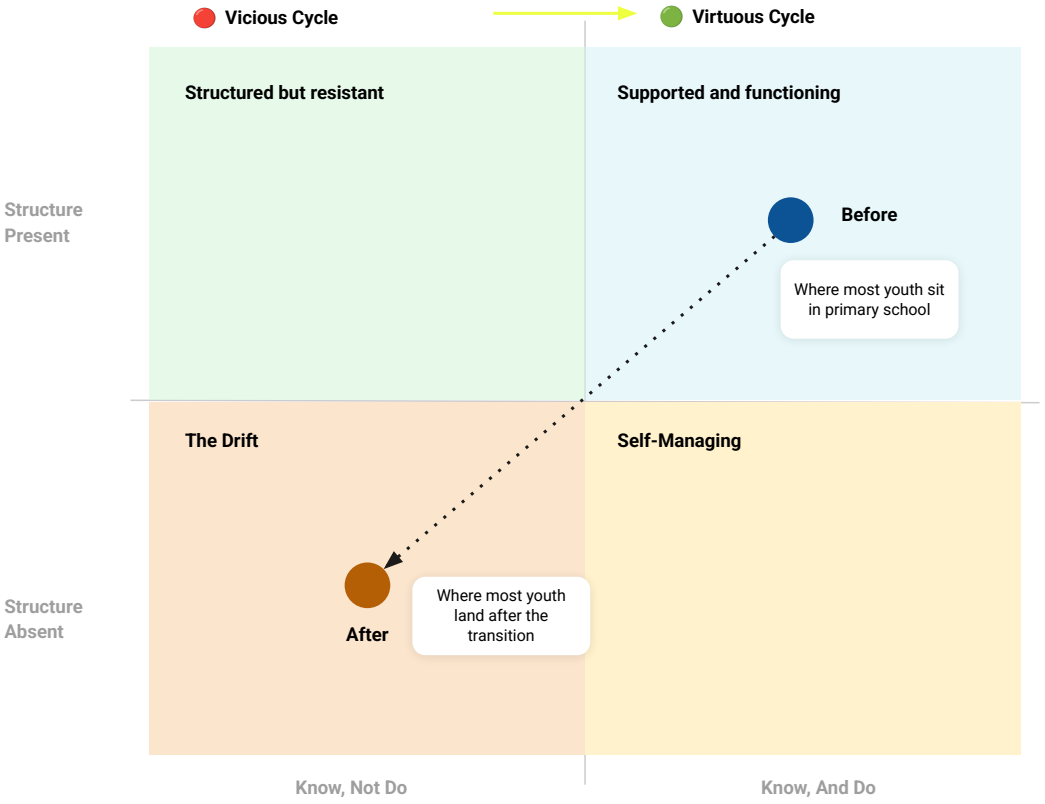
Youth starts drifting (sleeping later, eating McD with friends after school). Parent notices and reaches for the tools they know: take the phone, set a curfew. Youth pushes back or finds workarounds. One parent said his son ran away to a friend's house. Another's daughter used the helper's phone after pretending to sleep. The tools that worked for a 9-year-old do not work on a 13-year-old.

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR DESIGN

This is the best window to step in. The old routines haven't fully disappeared yet. Youth are still open to guidance, as long as it comes with explanation and feels fair. One parent said: "If this stage broken then very hard to counter in the future."

DESIGN IMPLICATION

Put new routines in place before the old support is completely gone. Concepts: self-set bedtime routines, trust conversations at Sec 1, phone-free dinner as an anchor ritual, gradual rules starting from dinner outward.



Secondary 2 → Secondary 3: The deepening drift

WHAT CHANGES

Peer influence becomes the stronger force. After-school time is fully shaped by friends. Fast food becomes a daily social ritual, not a food choice. Conversations with parents narrow to reminders: "did you eat," "go sleep," "stop your phone." Youth tunes them out. Both sides gradually stop talking about health altogether.

THE VICIOUS CYCLE HERE

Youth is stuck in the left half of the map, bouncing between the drift and structured but resistant. The cascade kicks in: screen time goes up, sleep goes down, eating suffers, exercise drops. 8 out of 11 youth and 5 out of 10 parents described this exact pattern. Parents either double down on rules (pushing youth into top-left) or give up entirely (leaving youth in bottom-left).

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR DESIGN

This is the leverage window. Habits haven't solidified into adult patterns yet. Youth are still malleable. But the intervention can't come through parents alone because that channel has narrowed. It has to come through peers, environment, and co-owned routines.

DESIGN IMPLICATION

Work through peer systems and environment redesign, not parental enforcement. Concepts: physical tiredness as sleep strategy, cold room for sleep, peer fining for fast food, group eating at hawker, board games at hangout spots.

Secondary 4 → JC / IHL: The fork

WHAT CHANGES

Structure is almost entirely gone. Youth is functionally self-governing. New environment (JC, Poly, ITE) resets social context. Peer group changes. Daily schedule changes. This is either the moment patterns from Sec 1-3 solidify into adult habits, or the fresh start where new routines take hold.

THE VICIOUS CYCLE HERE

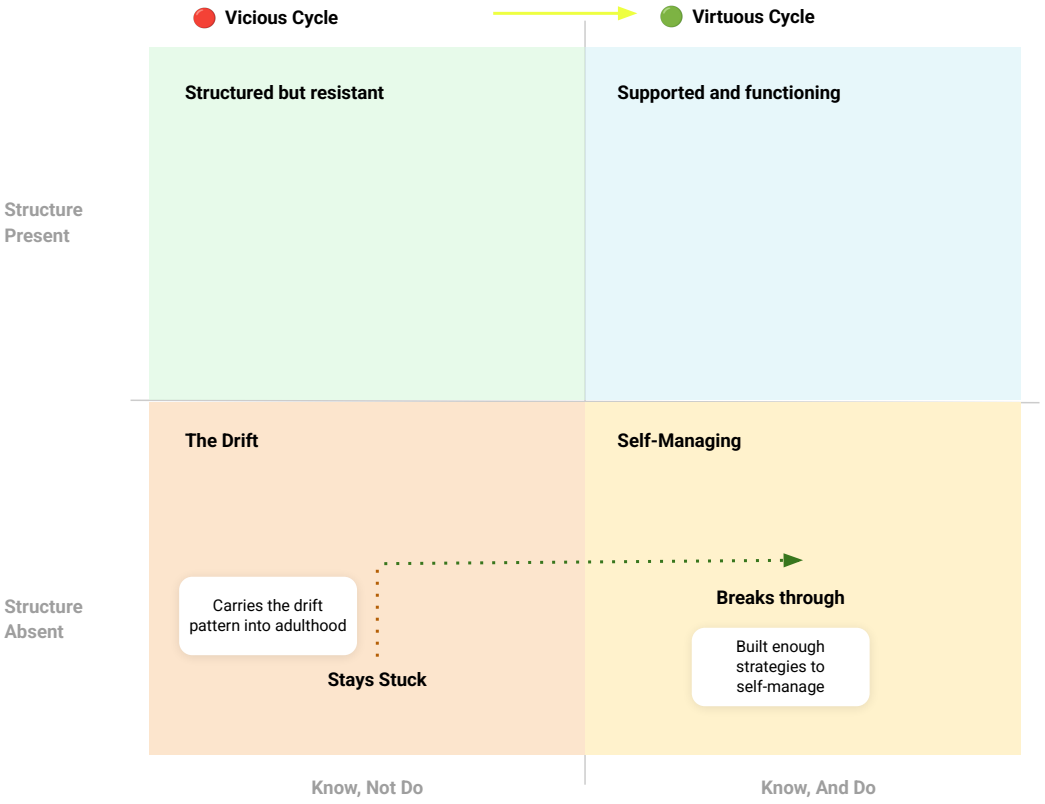
Youth who built some self-management strategies during Sec 1-3 have something to carry into the new environment. They land bottom-right: self-managing. Youth who were stuck in the vicious cycle (drift ↔ resistant) carry those patterns forward. They land bottom-left: still drifting, but now with even less structure and no one watching.

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR DESIGN

This transition is outside our target scope (13-16), but it's the reason our intervention window matters. What we build for Sec 1-3 determines which path youth take at the fork. If they reach Sec 4 with practical strategies and self-management capability, the fork bends toward self-managing.

DESIGN IMPLICATION

Our concepts aren't just solving for today. They're building the capability youth need to navigate the fork. Every self-set bedtime routine, every peer accountability system, every co-owned dinner ritual is an investment in the youth's ability to self-manage when structure is fully gone.



Opportunity Space (three jobs to solve)

What youth need, what parents need, and what the environment needs to make the healthy choice easier.

Youth

“When I am tired after school or at night, I need small steps that fit my routine so the healthy choice feels easy.”

Parent

“When I cannot see what my youth is doing, I need ways to stay supportive without nagging or spying.”

Ecosystem (schools, peers, places, platforms)

“When youth are in school and hangout spaces, the default environment should make healthier routines easier to start and repeat.”

North Star Vision

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North Star:

“The healthy choice becomes the natural choice and we flip the drift”

Empowered Transitions

Support at the moments where habits drift

Primary 6 to Secondary 1, Secondary 2 to Secondary 3, and Secondary 4 to Poly or JC. These are the moments when routines reset and influence shifts. We will support youth with practical tools that fit their real day, not lectures.

Shared Rhythm

Turn ‘windows’ into shared routines

It’s not about constant monitoring or stepping back completely. It’s about small shared routines that both sides help shape. The relationship itself becomes the structure, not a set of rules.

Confidence Loop

Build autonomy through small wins that strengthen trust and routines

Young people try something, it works, parents notice, trust grows and with that, youth gain more freedom. It’s a positive cycle that builds on itself

Anchored to: "How might we motivate youth and their key supporters to build confidence to start and sustain healthy habits, so healthier choices become natural as routines change and independence grows?"

Design Principles

Each principle resolves a core tension from the research.
They guide what we design and what we do not.

01

Autonomy with guardrails

Design for shared structure, not control.

It's not about choosing between freedom or control. It needs both where youth decide how things are done and parents work together on the timing. Together, they create a structure that works for both sides.

02

Replace, do not restrict

Never restrict behaviour without introducing alternatives

Taking something away only works if you replace it with something else. Screens and fast food are not just habits, they meet emotional and social needs. If you remove them without offering alternatives, youth will find workarounds. The goal is to design what fills that space.

03

Make it fit the day they already have

Strengthen existing behaviours before introducing new ones.

Youth are already supporting each other, and parents are doing the same through informal networks. They are on the track, but sometimes there is limited structure in place to back them up.

Shortlisted Concepts

Available in the separate document

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DVF (Desirability, Viability, Feasibility)

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Design constraints we will hold ourselves to

Programme + research constraints, updated into practical “design checks”.

Hard constraints (must-haves)

- Must stay within the 6 Wells scope: Learn, Eat, Exercise, Sleep, Oral
- Must be for secondary school youth (13–16) and parents
- Must be pilot-ready for small internal testing (about 30 youth, 10 parents)
- Must include non-digital ways to take part (it will not be app-only)
- Must not conflict with GWSG Message House calls-to-action

Reality checks from research

- Do not lead with “health”. Lead with what matters now: energy, confidence, performance
- It must work without parent policing (monitoring often creates pushback)
- It must survive exam and tuition weeks (stress-test: a normal Tuesday with homework due)
- Shared activities can bond or embarrass. Framing decides which one happens
- Habits are linked (screen ↔ sleep ↔ energy ↔ eating/movement). Avoid single-well fixes
- If it does not fit their routine, it will not stick (quick, repeatable, not socially awkward)

Fairness and ownership

- Assume tight budgets and time: free or low-cost, time-light, easy to access (no paid gear assumptions)
- Be clear who owns what across home and school (do not assume “someone else” will handle it)
- Oral health drops around 12–15. Make it immediate and visible, and tie it to snacking / eating

DVF: how we assessed concepts

A structured way to prioritise ideas that youth will do, HPB can run, and we can test quickly.

Desirability (Youth + Parent pull)

Areas:
- Meets a real tension in the drift
- Respects autonomy; feels non-awkward
- Youth would engage without being forced

What we scored (Excel criteria):
- D1 Evidence density (how often it surfaced across youth/parents)
- D2 Strategic compliance test (can youth easily “get around it”?)
- D3 Parent say–do test (works even if parents do not change)
- D4 Works when comms has narrowed (low-trust / low-talk households)
- D5 Survives academic pressure (tuition/exam weeks)
- D6 Anchored to youth concerns (energy, confidence, performance, social ease)
- D7 Parent energy (realistic effort given stress/time)

Viability

Areas:
- Aligns to GWSG + HPB direction
- Safe, equitable, within scope
- Credible for parents

What we scored / gated (Excel criteria):
- V1 Fits HPB ecosystem (Gate + Score)
- V2 Pilot-ready at small scale (Gate P/F)
- V3 Affordable for families
- V4 Clear ownership (youth/parent/school — no diffusion)
- V5 Aligns with GWSG Message House (Gate P/F)
- V6 Non-digital option exists

Feasibility

Areas:
- Prototype quickly; test with our sample
- Minimal dependencies (school/vendor/infrastructure)
- Clear behaviours + measurable signals

What we scored (Excel criteria):
- F1 Prototypable with lightweight materials
- F2 Produces evidence in testing window
- F3 Works without facilitator (self-guided at home)
- F4 Can recruit both parties if co-owned
- F5 Cascade potential (pulls multiple Wells)

How constraints + DVF were used

From long list to prioritised list to shortlist for next week's testing

1. Compile longlist - Consolidate all co-creation concept outputs (no early elimination).
2. Apply constraints - Use programme + research constraints as non-negotiable checks to remove misfits.
3. Score with DVF - Apply soft scoring plus gates so concepts can be compared like-for-like and non-viable options drop out.
4. Arrive with shortlist - Bring a proposed top 4 that best fits the North Star moments and is pilot-ready.
5. Refine and choose 1-2 - Work with HPB/YPS to stress-test the top 4, tighten the concept direction, and select 1-2 to take into prototyping and testing next.

Validation

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Validation: Methodology & Participant

Objectives

- Test usability & clarity
  - How easily participants understand and use each prototype
- Assess real-life fit
  - When/where prototypes fit family routines
- Capture reactions
  - Emotional responses and relationship impact
- Check role clarity
  - How prototypes define youth/parent/school responsibilities
- Prioritise next steps
  - Features to keep, change or drop

Methodology

- Individual 60-minute online sessions with 12 youth (13–16 years old) + 12 parent
- Moderated session
  - Warm-up (10 minutes): Conversation about daily routines, key pressure points and current approaches to health and routines
  - Prototype testing (35–40 minutes): Hands-on interaction with 2–3 early concepts using realistic scenarios and think-aloud protocol
  - Per-prototype ratings (5–10 minutes): Five 7-point Likert scale questions capturing overall experience, likelihood of use, ease, pressure/control perception and routine fit
  - Final ranking (5 minutes): Participants rank prototypes from most to least preferred and explain their reasoning.

Participants

- Youths: **n=12**
  - n=6 (13-14 years old)
  - n=6 (15-16 years old)
- Parents: **n=12** (aligned with HPB)
  - To include:
    - Active parents deeply engage with their youth
    - transgenerational family
    - to include experienced parents (parents with child >18 y/o)

Thank you

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